



Employee Handbook & Orientation Guide

Bright Beginnings Preschool

2025–2026 Staff Edition • Est. 1984

This handbook is provided for the exclusive use of Bright Beginnings Preschool staff members. All information contained herein is confidential and proprietary.

A Warm Welcome to the Bright Beginnings Family

Dear New Team Member,

Welcome to Bright Beginnings Preschool — we are so glad you are here.

Since 1984, Bright Beginnings has been more than a preschool. We are a community — one built on trust, warmth, professional excellence, and a genuine love for children and families. Every person who joins our team becomes part of something meaningful, and we do not take that lightly.

This handbook is your guide to the policies, expectations, and culture that make Bright Beginnings what it is. We ask that you read it carefully and refer back to it throughout your time with us. It reflects years of experience and a deep commitment to doing this work the right way — for our children, our families, and for each other.

You will find that we hold high expectations here — for ourselves and for everyone on our team. We do so not to be demanding, but because the children and families we serve deserve nothing less than our very best. At the same time, we are committed to supporting you, growing with you, and celebrating you along the way.

Our Core Values — Communicate, Play, Trust, Family, Nurture, and Learn — are not just words on a page. They guide how we show up every day: with each other, with the children, and with the families who trust us with their most precious people.

We are honored that you have chosen to join us. Please do not hesitate to ask questions, lean on your colleagues, and bring your full self to this work. This is a place where great teachers thrive.

Again — welcome. We are so glad you are part of our family.

With warmth and excitement,

The Bright Beginnings Leadership Team

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SECTION 1

Who We Are

Our Mission, Philosophy, Values, and Culture

Our Mission & Philosophy

Our Mission

Our mission is to provide a high quality, safe, and nurturing early childhood program for preschool children while supporting each unique family unit. We strive to allow each child to develop at his or her own rate with the goal of a successful transition into kindergarten and beyond.

Our Philosophy

- Each child has unique interests and abilities and we encourage children to gain confidence by trying new activities.
- Our goal is to provide a play based, Reggio-Inspired, creative curriculum that supports each child's social, emotional, cognitive and physical growth.
- We believe children are naturally curious and by providing a balance of well-guided teacher encounters along with child initiated activities, children develop confidence as they grow and learn while having fun.
- Learning in a supportive environment with small groups of peers allows students to become independent critical thinkers, have confidence to try new activities and interact socially. Our teachers monitor developmental milestones and document each child's individual progress.
- Children are competent learners who naturally seek to engage in interesting activities. We plan activities designed to nurture the whole child by listening to their interests and developing learning activities around those interests.
- Our staff facilitate interesting learning activities, use various forms of documentation, and analyze children's words and work, modeling their own love of learning.
- Curriculum areas include quality literature, language arts, math, science lab, creative art, music and movement, art appreciation, Outdoor Classroom, tinkering and social skills.
- We recognize that the school environment is an essential element of a high quality program and consider the entire school as the classroom, encouraging teachers to plan activities throughout the building.
- We utilize the outdoor education spaces unique to each school campus to promote learning throughout the day.

Our Core Values

We are a FAMILY, we NURTURE one another and LEARN through PLAY, while creating TRUST and COMMUNICATING with KINDNESS.

COMMUNICATE

Keeping open and transparent communication solves almost every issue — please ask questions!

PLAY

When children are given ample time to explore their world and interact with trusted caregivers and each other, learning is natural!

TRUST

Young children begin to trust the world outside of their immediate family when they develop relationships with safe, nurturing adults.

FAMILY

When you join Bright Beginnings, you become part of a strong early childhood community, continually growing and learning together.

NURTURE

Nurturing children comes naturally to us — but we also nurture each other and our families.

LEARN

We believe in lifelong learning for children, teachers and families.

Our Family Culture

Building a school community takes full participation and commitment from parents, teachers, and administration. Bright Beginnings Preschool serves children and families best when a strong culture and positive environment are promoted.

Families at Bright Beginnings:

- Respect all children, staff, and fellow parents.
- Are willing to communicate positively and effectively with teachers and administration promptly.
- Are proactive when questions arise and work collaboratively with the school to resolve issues.
- Support the mission of the school by providing feedback, comments, constructive critiques, volunteering, and meeting financial obligations.
- Understand and follow licensing and health and safety policies.
- Understand and respect that school buildings and properties are smoke, vape, drug, alcohol, and firearm free.

Staff Culture

Our staff agrees that maintaining a professional and friendly work environment helps us serve our families and their children best. We are committed to participating fully and supporting our Staff Culture. All staff sign the Staff Culture statement before starting work.

- We love children and respect the uniqueness of each family.
- We love to learn and are committed to lifelong learning.
- We understand that all enrolled children are ALL our responsibility.
- We have a high level of positive energy and solve problems in an honest, confidential, and collaborative manner.
- We focus on organization, attention to detail, and strong systems; we take directions well and understand the structure of our organization.
- We understand that a high level of flexibility and teamwork is necessary to provide optimal care.
- We choose to model a healthy lifestyle and conduct ourselves professionally at work and home, always with strong moral character.
- We are proud to serve as community ambassadors for Bright Beginnings.

SECTION 2

Policies & Expectations

Rules of Conduct, Attendance, Dress Code, Cell Phone, Confidentiality, Non-Smoking/Drug, Resignation

Rules of Conduct

It is important to understand that no code of conduct can replace the thoughtful behavior of an ethical employee. However, Bright Beginnings Preschool's essential objective is to uphold the highest standards of ethical conduct in all of its activities. It is expected that every employee will understand this code and always follow it.

OFFENSES RESULTING IN IMMEDIATE DISMISSAL:

- Insubordination — refusal to comply with instructions of supervisor
- Refusal to accept a proper job assignment or reasonable overtime request
- Falsifying application for employment or sign-in/work records
- Immoral conduct of any kind (drinking, drugs, sexual)
- Fighting, horseplay, or verbal arguments including raised voices
- Malicious damage to company property or unauthorized removal of property
- Failure to adhere to core values and staff culture
- Child abuse or neglect
- Reporting to work under the influence of alcohol or narcotics
- Inappropriate use of technology or social media, including posting pictures of children

Offenses resulting in Disciplinary Action (repeated = dismissal):

- Excessive absenteeism or tardiness
- Leaving the classroom or building during work hours without permission
- Use of obscene, abusive, or threatening language
- Unauthorized use of the telephone for personal use
- Creating unsafe or unsanitary conditions
- Smoking anywhere on or near the property
- Unauthorized use or disclosure of information or records
- Unsupportive or negative behavior/comments regarding the company, staff, or program
- Inability to perform job functions as needed

In all activities and interactions, we expect:

- Leadership — in the way that we interact with coworkers and customers, developing and contributing professionally to our program.
- Integrity — practicing the highest ethical standards, taking responsibility for our actions, and treating everyone fairly with trust and respect.

Attendance & Call Out Policy

In order to run a quality program, staff must be at work each day. It is important for children's development to have consistency which includes their classroom teachers each day.

If you find yourself unable to attend work:

- You **MUST** call and speak to the opening supervisor or the Director at least 2 hours prior to your scheduled shift.
- You may send a courtesy text to the Director and opening supervisor at any time to give a heads up, but you **MUST** also follow up with a phone call.
- You will try to come to work unless you are running a fever or vomiting until a sub is secured for you to go home.
- You are responsible for bringing in a doctor's note for ANY time missed due to illness.
- Attendance is tracked weekly/monthly by your site director; taking more time off than permitted is grounds for probation, pay decrease, and termination.
- Poor attendance will be documented in evaluations and affect performance reviews and raises.

Important Note

Any absence not covered by a doctor's note or prior approval may result in disciplinary action. We highly recommend taking daily vitamins, getting a flu shot, and practicing excellent hand hygiene.

Dress Code

Bright Beginnings maintains a professional dress standard appropriate to a childcare environment. Please review all requirements carefully before your first day.

PERMITTED attire:

- Skirts, “skorts”, dresses, and jumpers must be at the knee. In fall and winter, tights or leggings are required.
- Dressy leggings with pockets, belt loops or piping (not yoga pants) with a long top fully covering your bottom.
- Athletic shoes (New Balance, Nike, Adidas) are acceptable for outdoor classroom/playground times.
- Fashion sneakers are permitted (Tom’s, Keds, Vans, Converse).
- Pants in solid colors (khakis, capris, cropped), colored denim, denim skirts and jumpers.
- Keep a sweater, cardigan, BB sweatshirt, or solid-colored zippered hoodie in your classroom.

NOT PERMITTED:

- Shorts, very short mini skirts, sweatpants, or workout gear.
- T-shirts or sweatshirts with writing or logos (except Bright Beginnings issued clothing).
- Uniforms of any sort, including hospital scrubs.
- Hats or headgear (except Bright Beginnings issued).
- Low cut or low v-neck showing cleavage — wear a camisole or tank top underneath.
- Open-toed shoes, flip flops, or sandals (insurance requirement — mulch and classroom hazards require sturdy footwear).
- Blue jeans or blue jean shorts/skorts.
- Jackets worn in the classroom (looks unprofessional — use a cardigan or BB hoodie instead).

You should NOT look like you are going to the gym or a social event when arriving at work. Professional, warm, and active — that is the standard.

Cell Phone & Technology Policy

We are committed to creating a nurturing and engaging environment for our children. Cell phones are a distraction from proper supervision and are strictly regulated.

- Cell phones and smart watches are NOT allowed in classrooms or playgrounds. They must be left in your car or locked in the office.
- The use of headphones or earbuds is prohibited in classrooms and playgrounds.
- Personal electronics, including cell phones, are only allowed while on break and NEVER when children are present.
- Never take or send pictures of children in your care to personal devices.
- Never share information or pictures of the children in your care on personal social media platforms.
- Each classroom has a tablet for Tadpoles and curriculum planning ONLY. Teachers are strictly prohibited from using tablets or personal devices to show videos to children during class time.

Important Note

Your cell phone is NOT allowed while on the clock or in the presence of children. This is a non-negotiable safety policy. Any violations could result in immediate termination.

Confidentiality & Gossip Policy

Maintaining a positive and healthy work environment helps us serve our families and children best. Gossip can destroy a work environment, hurt feelings, and cause long-term trust issues. Participating in gossip — either as the speaker or the recipient — breaks Bright Beginnings policy rooted in our Core Values and can be grounds for immediate termination.

Understanding Gossip:

- Anything “discussed with someone who does not have the ability to fix the problem.”
- “Casual or unconstrained conversation about other people, typically involving details not confirmed as true.”

Your Commitments:

- Gossip, negativity, and complaining to team members who cannot solve issues are NOT tolerated.
- You will respect the confidentiality of all matters concerning children, families, colleagues, management, and our program.
- When you identify gossip, you will directly state: “This is gossip. I will not participate, and I suggest you speak with [director/administrator] about your concerns.”
- Gossip includes verbal, written, and all social media platforms — during work hours AND outside of work.
- Discussions about the needs of children belong in professional settings such as staff meetings or with your supervisor.

Non-Smoking & Drug Policy

The safety, health, and well-being of children are our top priorities. Bright Beginnings has a zero-tolerance policy regarding smoking, drugs, and other recreational/non-prescription products.

This policy applies to all staff, parents, and visitors at all Bright Beginnings locations:

- Smoking/vaping/microdosing/alcohol consumption is strictly prohibited on all preschool premises, including classrooms, playgrounds, parking lots, and any area where children are present. This includes cigarettes, cigars, e-cigarettes, THC, CBD, or any similar products.
- Teachers are not allowed to smoke during any preschool-related activities, field trips, or while supervising children off-site.
- Appearance and smell: Teachers and staff must not smell of tobacco products while on duty or interacting with children, parents, or colleagues. Second-hand smoke is dangerous to children. Bring a change of clothing, toothbrush, and toothpaste to ensure you are not sent home to change.
- Illegal substances: The use, possession, distribution, or sale of illegal drugs is strictly prohibited at all times. Any violation will result in immediate dismissal and likely police involvement.
- We randomly drug test.
- Prescription medication must be in accordance with a doctor's orders and must not impair your ability to perform duties safely.

Resignation Policy

Bright Beginnings values the time and effort each employee brings to our community. We ask that departures are handled with the same professionalism and care that you brought when you joined us.

- When resigning, staff **MUST** give at least a two-week notice in writing to their director and email notice to accounts@brightbeginningsva.com.
- Staff must keep their intentions confidential until a transition plan is in place. This means not informing children, parents, or co-workers of your intention to leave — allow the school to communicate this transition.
- To leave in good standing, Bright Beginnings requires at least a 30-day notice, allowing adequate time to hire, train, and transition a replacement.
- You **MUST** work the full 2 weeks with no RTOs or call-outs. Giving less than a 2-week notice will result in minimum wage for all upcoming paychecks.
- Staff are responsible for returning all Bright Beginnings materials upon leaving: t-shirts, sweatshirts, cups/mugs, teacher bags, name tags, and any other issued items. Unreturned items will be deducted from your final paycheck.
- All trainings paid for by Bright Beginnings will be deducted from your last paycheck, including: CPR/First Aid, MAT, CDA, conference fees, or other off-site training.

SECTION 3

Health, Safety & Procedures

Hand Washing, Cleaning, Infant Safety, Playground, New Staff Procedures

Hand Washing Procedures

Proper hand hygiene is a critical health and licensing requirement at Bright Beginnings.

Children MUST wash their hands with soap and water:

- Upon arriving at school.
- When coming inside from the playground.
- After diaper changes or using the toilet.
- Whenever they encounter bodily fluids.
- Before and after meals and snacks.
- After a messy art project.
- Infants who can hold their heads up are required to wash hands with soap and water — teachers must assist.

Staff are required to wash their hands with soap and water:

- When arriving at school.
- When coming inside from the playground.
- Before and after helping a child use the toilet or diapering.
- After the staff member uses the toilet or eats.
- After any contact with body fluids, including wiping noses or first aid assistance.
- Before and after feeding or helping children eat, including bottles.
- Before preparing or serving food or beverages.

Important Note

Hand washing compliance is monitored via classroom cameras and in-person observations. Non-compliance is a licensing violation.

Cleaning & Disinfecting Solutions

Spray bottles **MUST** be emptied each night and refilled with new solutions every morning.

CLEANING is done with soap and water solution:

- Before and after meals or activities at the tables.
- Before and after diaper changes.
- Anytime there is a mess made.

DISINFECTING is done with bleach solution:

Diaper Bleach Solution — used after each diaper change:

- First spray soap and water solution and wipe immediately.
- Then spray bleach solution and let sit for AT LEAST 2 minutes, then wipe with a wet paper towel.
- Before the next diaper change, be sure to clean again with soap and water solution.

Table Bleach Solution — used after meals or activities at tables:

- First spray soap and water solution and wipe immediately.
- Then spray bleach solution and let sit for AT LEAST 2 minutes, then wipe with a wet paper towel.
- Before the next meal or activity, clean again with soap and water solution.

Important Note

Two-step cleaning and disinfecting (soap, then bleach) is required by licensing. The bleach solution must sit for at least 2 full minutes to be effective. All cleaning materials must be stored out of reach of children and **LOCKED** when not in use.

Infant Safety & Head Trauma Awareness

This training is required by Virginia licensing for all staff working with infants and toddlers. If you ever suspect a child has been injured, seek immediate medical attention and notify your director right away.

Shaken Baby Syndrome / Abusive Head Trauma (SBS/AHT)

Shaken Baby Syndrome (SBS) is a form of child abuse that occurs when an infant or small child is violently shaken. SBS is completely preventable. In 25% of diagnosed cases, injuries prove fatal. Infants are most vulnerable during their first year of life due to heavy heads, weak neck muscles, and fragile, undeveloped brains.

Possible Signs and Symptoms:

- Lethargy or decreased muscle tone
- **Extreme irritability**
- **Decreased appetite, poor feeding, or vomiting for no apparent reason**
- **No smiling or vocalization**
- **Poor sucking or swallowing**
- **Difficulty breathing**
- **Seizures**
- **Soft spot on head appears to be bulging**
- **Inability to lift head**
- **Inability of eyes to focus or track movement**
- **Unequal size of pupils**

Infant Safe Sleep Practices:

- Always place infants on their backs to sleep.
- Resting or sleeping infants shall be individually checked every 15 minutes.
- Pillows and filled comforters are not permitted for children under two years of age.
- Blankets, pillows, toys, or any other objects are NOT allowed in cribs. Only non-weighted sleep sacks are permitted.
- Pacifiers may be used in cribs as long as they do not have a clip attached.
- Bibs, hoodies, or jackets must NOT be worn in cribs.

Playground Safety

Children should always remain within sight and sound of the adult responsible for monitoring them. Playground safety is the responsibility of ALL staff who enter and use the playground space.

Required Playground Standards:

- Ratios must be maintained at all times without exception.
- No child is allowed on a playground without an adult accompanying them.
- Supervision on the playground is active. Staff must stand, interact, and circulate.
- A staff member must always monitor and assist children while on playground equipment.
- Staff must spread out into zones to maintain full visualization of the entire playground.
- Teachers must NOT congregate. No standing with co-workers and talking. Attention should ALWAYS be on the children.
- Check the surface under playground equipment regularly at fall zones (6 feet around a play structure) to ensure adequate wood chip coverage.
- Check playground equipment for loose or protruding bolts, jagged edges, or sharp points.
- Classes must stay on playground schedules — too many children at once is a safety hazard.
- If two teachers are assigned to a classroom, BOTH never go outside together. One stays in the room.
- Position yourself so your back is NEVER to children.
- Always do a headcount and name-to-face count of children as you exit and return.
- Your walkie-talkie and tablet should always be present with you on the playground.
- Water bottles with student names and dates always go outdoors with children.
- Playground gates are to remain locked at all times.
- Sunscreen is applied by families each morning and by staff mid-day during warmer months.
- Be extra vigilant of wildlife during warmer months — alert your director immediately if wildlife is observed on the property.

Important Note

Sign-in logs are required before leaving the building each day. If you observe playground hazards, notify the director immediately.

New Staff & Substitute — Important Procedures

Welcome to Bright Beginnings! Thank you for all you do every day. Please read these procedures carefully. You are responsible for all of this information. Refer back to this document throughout your first days with us.

1. Arrive at least 10 minutes early. If you cannot arrive on time each day, your schedule will be adjusted.
2. Park at the far end of the parking lot and lock your car.
3. Do not bring anything into the building except a water bottle, tennis shoes for outdoor time, and a jacket or sweater.
4. Ring the doorbell and wait for someone to answer. Permanent staff will receive a 4-digit Brivo door code from their director. Never share your door code.
5. Leave your cell phone in your car or lock it in the office as soon as you enter. A cell phone seen in a classroom risks immediate termination — this is a major safety violation.
6. Locate your supervisor to confirm your room placement and assignments for the day.
7. Do not clock into Procare until a supervisor asks you to.
8. When entering the classroom, wash your hands, greet staff and children, and clock in on Tadpoles on your classroom tablet.
9. Be aware of any children with allergies in the classroom. Allergy lists are posted on the back of all classroom doors and noted in Tadpoles.
10. Read the Morning Message in its entirety and then sign it — it contains everything you need to know for the day.
11. You may not be alone with students unless cleared by the director (all paperwork completed, orientation and training finished, plus at least 6 months experience, OR in sight and sound of a direct supervisor).
12. There is no sitting in the classroom or on the playground. Always be engaging with children, cleaning, setting up activities, or assisting.
13. We monitor all classrooms with cameras throughout the day.
14. Children must be in sight and sound at ALL times. Constantly scan the room and always have eyes on the children.
15. You MUST know how many children are in your care at all times. Use the Name to Face roll call sheet every hour.
16. You may NEVER walk out of a room. You MUST be relieved by someone before leaving the classroom for ANY reason. Use the walkie-talkie discreetly for emergencies.
17. It is STRICTLY FORBIDDEN to take pictures of children or post anything related to your work on any social media.
18. At 4:30 every day, bring children inside. All children must have a diaper change or use the potty, hands and faces washed, and water provided.

Current Enhanced Staff-to-Child Ratios:

Infants: 1 teacher for every 5 students

Toddlers: 1 teacher for every 6 students

Twos: 1 teacher for every 9 students

Threes and Fours: 1 teacher for every 11 students

SECTION 4

Your Role & Growth

Career Development, Camera Observations, Customer Service

Career Ladder at Bright Beginnings

Bright Beginnings is committed to your professional growth. Career Ladder meetings are one-on-one sessions between you and your director designed to support your personal and professional development.

What is discussed in a Career Ladder meeting:

- Your current schedule, position, and standing (good standing or probation)
- Training hours completed year-to-date and any required training still needed
- Review of recent evaluations and documentation
- Your compensation package: hourly rate, insurance options, paid vacation and holidays, 401(k) eligibility, childcare discount, bonuses, and referral incentives
- Your daily, weekly, and monthly job responsibilities
- Your unique strengths (“Unique Brilliance”) and areas for growth
- Professional and personal goals with measurable outcomes
- Attendance record and expectations
- Your primary Language of Appreciation so leadership can recognize you effectively

Important Note

Career Ladder meetings are intended to support staff’s personal and professional growth and do not necessarily involve a raise or additional benefits. Ensuring all tasks are completed is the staff member’s responsibility.

Classroom Camera & In-Person Observations

Bright Beginnings monitors all classrooms with cameras throughout the day and conducts regular in-person observations. This is a quality assurance and licensing compliance measure that ensures the safety of children and supports your professional development.

Classroom Standards Observed:

- Clock in only when asked to by supervisor. Wait in kitchen or empty classroom, not lobby.
- Lights on at all times.
- No pacifiers unless the child is on mat or in crib.
- Children may not fall asleep in bouncer/swing — move immediately to crib.
- No cloth bibs — rubber bibs only when eating.
- No weighted sleep sacks, no blankets for 12 months and under.
- Tummy time documented twice daily for at least 30 minutes a day.
- No cell phone/Apple watches when you are in ratios.
- Proper hand washing: when student arrives, before/after meals and bottles, before/after inside/outside transitions, before/after diapering.
- Proper table and changing table disinfecting (soapy water first, then bleach water — let sit at least 2 minutes).
- Cleaning solutions/chemicals locked away when not in use.
- All children outside twice daily — on schedule, on correct playground.
- No sitting — constantly walking, circulating, and interacting with children.
- No plugging information into Tadpoles while outside; no chatting with staff while supervising.
- Lesson plans documented on Tadpoles in full sentences, past tense.
- Playground gates locked and bungee corded at all times.
- Injury reports completed and reported to director immediately.
- Cabinets and closets closed and locked at all times.
- Sign out logs done daily and given to director.
- Adheres to staff culture: positivity, no gossip.

Action Plan for Violations:

- Write-up (3 write-ups = immediate termination)
- Additional training
- Move to a different classroom or age group
- Schedule reduced temporarily
- Pay reduced temporarily

- Termination

Steps to Better Customer Listening

Our families trust us with their children. How we communicate with them matters enormously. The following standards guide every interaction between Bright Beginnings staff and the families we serve.

- Give families your full attention when they are speaking about their child or concerns.
- Show genuine interest in what parents are saying, even during busy moments.
- Help guide the conversation gently if needed, but keep the focus on what the parent wants to talk about.
- Take quick notes when families share important details about their child or situation.
- Ask clear follow-up questions to better understand their concerns or needs.
- Repeat back key points to make sure you understood their message correctly.
- Confirm your understanding by summarizing and asking, “Did I get that right?”
- Use welcoming body language — eye contact, nodding, and a warm tone — to show you’re engaged.
- Avoid interrupting so parents feel fully heard and respected.
- Stay calm and professional, even if a parent is emotional or upset.
- Limit distractions by stepping away from phones or screens during conversations with families.
- Use the family’s name when appropriate to make the interaction more personal.
- Acknowledge emotions and let parents know it is okay to feel worried, frustrated, or confused.
- Follow up with families after a concern has been shared to show you care and took action.
- Reflect on the feedback to help improve communication and care for all children.

SECTION 5

Technology & Communication

Tadpoles App User Guide & Cell Phone Policy Reference

Tadpoles User Guide — For Teachers

Training Video: <http://help.tadpoles.com/customer/portal/articles/1631935-teacher-training-video> Watch the introductory training video before your first day using Tadpoles.

Sticky Notes

Sticky notes are located on the front dashboard and are a way for the Director to notify you of children's extra days, vacation or sick days, pickup information, and birthdays. When there are change requests to your lesson plan, you will receive a sticky note notifying you.

Checking In — Yourself

Check In: When arriving at school and going into classroom. Move: When moving out of one class into another. Sign Out: When going on break (not assigned to any classroom). Sign In: When returning from break. Check Out: When done for the day.

Checking In — Children

Slide to the roster screen to see all checked-in children. Check a child in by tapping their face and selecting "Check In". If a child is not showing in your class, switch to All Classrooms and search there. Notify the Director if a child is assigned the wrong classroom.

Daily Reports

Daily reports are updated throughout the day via the Daily Profile Screen (third swipe on iPad). DO NOT select "Send Now" — parents automatically receive the Daily via email at 1:30 for half-day children and within 2 minutes of checkout for full-day children. All Daily Activity updates MUST be completed by 1:00 pm (half-day) or 3:00 pm (full-day).

Photos

Use the iPad's native camera app for better resolution, then assign to the child's Daily via the Tadpoles Photo screen. Send photos to "Daily Report" — NOT "Email" — to avoid multiple emails to parents. One photo of each child should be taken every day. Children on the No Photo list will display "NP" on their profile — never include these children in photos.

Lesson Planning

Lesson plans can be added up to 4 weeks in advance on the iPad app or at tadpoles.com. Write descriptions in past tense (the parents read them after the fact). Only the Description section goes home

to parents — Goals and Materials sections are for staff and administrators only. Plans display as: Green = approved, Red = changes requested, Blue = not yet approved.

Troubleshooting

Random children in wrong class: Double-click circle, close and reopen app. Items in Outbox while in WiFi: Log out and log back in. iPad won't refresh: Delete Tadpoles app and reinstall. iPad won't charge: Turn Airplane mode ON, power off for 20 seconds, power back on, then turn Airplane mode OFF. Technical support: Hello@Tadpoles.com

SECTION 6

Licensing & Training Requirements

Virginia Licensing Standards, Required Trainings, Annual Log Reference

Licensing & Training Requirements

Bright Beginnings is regulated by the Virginia Department of Social Services. All staff must meet state licensing requirements, including required trainings before and shortly after hire. The following is a reference list of what belongs in your staff file.

Staff File Licensing Checklist (Reference)

- Application (including Emergency Contact Information)
- References
- Licensing Orientation Checklist
- Fingerprints (Fieldprint)
- Central Registry Search
- Sworn Disclosure Statement
- Out-of-State background checks (if applicable)
- TB Test / TB Screening Form

Required Trainings:

- Child Abuse and Neglect
- Preservice 10-hour training
- Preservice 3-hour training
- Health Screening for Childcare Professionals
- CPR / First Aid
- Infant Head Trauma
- Playground Safety
- Proof of Education

Annual Training Requirement: All staff are required to complete ongoing annual training hours as specified by Virginia licensing standards. Keep all training certificates. Your Annual Training Log must be updated and submitted to your director. Attach all certificates to your log.

SECTION 7

Our Team Culture

Languages of Appreciation, Enneagram, Favorite Things

Understanding Our Team Culture

At Bright Beginnings, we believe that a healthy, appreciative team culture makes everything better — for children, for families, and for each other. We use several tools to help our team members understand themselves, connect with colleagues, and feel genuinely valued.

5 Languages of Appreciation

Understanding how your colleagues feel appreciated helps us build a stronger team. Each person has a primary language — learn yours and your teammates’.

Words of Affirmation

Oral and written words used to affirm and encourage. Some prefer personal one-on-one communication; others value being praised in front of others.

Quality Time

Personal, focused time and attention. Some enjoy hanging out with co-workers, working together on a project, or just having someone take the time to listen.

Acts of Service

Assisting in getting a task done — helping a teammate dig out from being behind, working together on a difficult project, or just working alongside on a task.

Tangible Gifts

The key is the thoughtfulness, not the amount spent. Notice what your colleagues enjoy — chocolate, coffee, gift cards, hobbies — and use that knowledge.

Appropriate Physical Touch

Usually occurs spontaneously in celebration — high fives, fist bumps, a pat on the back, a handshake. This should always be appropriate and consensual.

You'll complete a Languages of Appreciation form during onboarding so your director and team can learn your preferred style. Physical copies of the form are available at each location.

The Enneagram

The Enneagram is a personality typing system that helps us better understand ourselves and each other. At Bright Beginnings, we use it as a team-building tool — not as a judgment or box to put you in, but as a starting point for conversation and self-awareness.

Take the free Enneagram assessment at enneagramtest.com and bring your result (number and wing) to share with your team. You'll be asked to complete a brief form noting your Enneagram number during onboarding.

Favorite Things

One of the ways we show appreciation at Bright Beginnings is through small, thoughtful gestures — a favorite snack, a gift card to a favorite restaurant, flowers on your birthday. During onboarding, you'll fill out a Favorite Things form that helps your director and colleagues know what makes you feel celebrated.

This form is kept on file and referenced throughout the year for birthdays, milestones, appreciation events, and any time we just want to say thank you. Physical copies of the form are available at each location.